郑和下西洋

一个通事的海上记忆

Zheng He Sails the Western Seas

An Interpreter Remembers the Treasure Fleet

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 六百多年前，明朝[1]的皇帝[2]派郑和[3]带领一支巨大的船队，从中国出发，一路向西。从1405年到1433年，这支船队一共七次出海，最远到过阿拉伯半岛[4]和非洲[5]东岸。当时的人把这些海上的地方叫做“西洋[6]”。下面这个故事里的少年阿里[7]是编出来的人物，可是他看到的船、星星和港口[8]，在历史上都能找到记录。

泉州[9]的少年

2 1412年冬天，泉州港口旁边的墙上贴出了一张通知。很多人围在前面，有人大声地念：“朝廷[10]的船队将于[11]明年出海，前往西洋各国，现需要会说外国话的通事[12]……”

1 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
2 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
3 郑和 *Zhèng Hé* Zheng He (1371–1433?), admiral of the fleet
4 阿拉伯半岛 *Ālābó Bàndǎo* the Arabian Peninsula
5 非洲 *Fēizhōu* Africa
6 西洋 *Xīyáng* the Western Seas
7 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
8 港口 *gǎngkǒu* port
9 泉州 *Quánzhōu* Quanzhou, port city in Fujian
10 朝廷 *cháotíng* imperial court
11 于 *yú* in, at (formal)
12 通事 *tōngshì* interpreter

More than six hundred years ago, an emperor of the Ming dynasty sent Zheng He at the head of a vast fleet, setting out from China and sailing ever westward. Between 1405 and 1433 the fleet put to sea seven times, reaching as far as the Arabian Peninsula and the east coast of Africa. People at the time called these lands across the sea the "Western Seas". Ali, the young man in the story below, is invented, but the ships, stars and ports he sees can all be found in the historical record. 1

The Young Man from Quanzhou

In the winter of 1412, a notice was posted on a wall beside the port of Quanzhou. A crowd gathered in front of it, and someone read it out loud: "The fleet of the imperial court will put to sea next year, bound for the lands of the Western Seas. Men who can speak foreign tongues are now needed as interpreters..." 2

十七岁的阿里[1]挤进人群，把通知看了一遍又一遍，心跳得越来越快。

阿里家本来是波斯[2]商人，一百多年前坐船来到泉州[3]，从此在这里住了下来。那时候的泉州是世界上最热闹的港口[4]之一，街上到处是各国的商人。阿里的爷爷会说波斯话，也会写阿拉伯文[5]。阿里从小跟着爷爷学习，所以除了汉语，他还能说两种外国话。

回到家，阿里把通知的事告诉了父亲。父亲正在店里称胡椒[6]，听完以后，放下手里的东西，很不高兴地说："凭你会说几句外国话，就想上宝船[7]？海上有风暴[8]，有病，一去就是两年。你知道有多少人没能回来吗？"阿里说："爸爸，爷爷常说，我们家的人是坐船来的。现在有机会坐船出去看看，我为什么不去？"

1 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
2 波斯 *Bōsī* Persia
3 泉州 *Quánzhōu* Quanzhou, port city in Fujian
4 港口 *gǎngkǒu* port
5 阿拉伯文 *Ālābówén* Arabic (written language)
6 胡椒 *hújiāo* black pepper
7 宝船 *bǎochuán* treasure ship
8 风暴 *fēngbào* storm

Seventeen-year-old Ali squeezed into the crowd and read the notice over and 2
over, his heart beating faster and faster.

Ali's family had originally been Persian merchants; more than a hundred 3
years earlier they had come to Quanzhou by ship and settled there. In those days Quanzhou was one of the busiest ports in the world, and its streets were full of merchants from every land. Ali's grandfather could speak Persian and write Arabic. Ali had studied with his grandfather since he was small, so besides Chinese he could speak two foreign languages.

When he got home, Ali told his father about the notice. His father was 4
weighing pepper in the shop. When he had heard Ali out, he put down what he was holding and said crossly: "Just because you can speak a few words of foreign languages, you think you can board the treasure ships? At sea there are storms and sickness, and once you leave, you're gone for two years. Do you know how many men never came back?" Ali said, "Dad, Grandpa always said our family came here by ship. Now I have the chance to go out by ship and see the world. Why shouldn't I go?"

父亲没有回答，只是叹[1]了一口气。

几天以后，阿里[2]去参加了考试。考官拿出一封用阿拉伯文[3]写的信，让他当场翻译成汉语。阿里读得很慢，可是每一句都翻译得很准确。凭着爷爷教他的这些本领，阿里被选上了。离开家的那天早上，父亲把一个小布袋放在他手里，里面装着一些胡椒[4]。“带着吧，”父亲说，“到了外面，闻一闻，就会想起家。”

宝船[5]

1413年，阿里来到福建[6]长乐[7]的海边。船队已经从南京[8]开到了这里，正在等冬天的东北风[9]。阿里第一次看到宝船的时候，站在岸上，半天说不出话来。

1 叹 *tàn* to sigh
2 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
3 阿拉伯文 *Ālābówén* Arabic (written language)
4 胡椒 *hújiāo* black pepper
5 宝船 *bǎochuán* treasure ship
6 福建 *Fújiàn* Fujian province
7 长乐 *Chánglè* Changle, harbour in Fujian
8 南京 *Nánjīng* Nanjing, then the capital
9 东北风 *dōngběifēng* northeast monsoon

His father didn't answer; he only sighed. 4

A few days later, Ali went to sit the examination. The examiner took out a letter written in Arabic and had him translate it into Chinese on the spot. Ali read slowly, but he translated every sentence accurately. On the strength of the skills his grandfather had taught him, Ali was chosen. On the morning he left home, his father put a small cloth bag in his hand. Inside were some peppercorns. "Take them," his father said. "When you're out there, smell them, and you'll think of home." 5

The Treasure Ships

In 1413 Ali arrived on the coast at Changle in Fujian. The fleet had already sailed down from Nanjing and was waiting here for the northeast winds of winter. When Ali first saw the treasure ships, he stood on the shore, unable to speak for a long while. 6

6 那些船像一座座会移动的城市，一张张巨大的船帆[†]在风里打开，高得好像能碰到天上的云。阿里[‡]心里想：有这样的船队，哪个国家敢不尊重中国呢？

7 一位姓陈[§]的老船员[¶]看他吃惊的样子，笑着说：“第一次见吧？听说最大的宝船[*]上能住好几百人。站在上面，就像站在陆地上一样稳。”后来的史书记载，最大的宝船长四十四丈[#]，宽十八丈，换算成今天的单位，长一百多米。不过，今天很多学者认为，用木头很难造出这么大的船，真正的宝船可能要小一些。它们到底有多大，到现在还没有人能说清楚。

8 这次出海的船队，据说有六十多条大船，再加上各种小船，一共可能有一百多条，也有人说更多。

† 船帆 *chuánfān* sail
‡ 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
§ 陈 *Chén* Chen (surname)
¶ 船员 *chuányuán* sailor
* 宝船 *bǎochuán* treasure ship
\# 丈 *zhàng* zhang, old unit (about 3 m)

The ships were like moving cities, and their great sails opened one after another in the wind, so high they seemed to touch the clouds. Ali thought: with a fleet like this, what country would dare not respect China? 6

An old sailor named Chen saw how astonished he was and said with a laugh: "First time you've seen them, eh? They say the biggest treasure ships can hold several hundred people. Standing on one feels as steady as standing on dry land." Later histories record that the largest treasure ships were forty-four zhang long and eighteen zhang wide, which in today's units means more than a hundred metres long. Many scholars today, however, believe it would be very hard to build a wooden ship that large, and that the real treasure ships were probably somewhat smaller. Exactly how big they were, no one can yet say for certain. 7

The fleet on this voyage is said to have had more than sixty large ships; with all the smaller vessels added, there may have been over a hundred in all, and some say even more. 8

8 船上的人大约有两万七千，有士兵、船员[1]、医生、造船的师傅，也有像阿里[2]这样的通事[3]。由于人多，需要的东西也多，因此每条船上都装满了粮食、淡水和各种货，以便船队在海上走几个月也不会缺少什么。

9 出发前几天，所有的通事都被叫到了郑和[4]的船上。据说郑和个子很高，说话的声音很大。他本来姓马，是云南[5]人，家里信伊斯兰教[6]，跟阿里家一样。郑和看了看这些年轻人，说："你们的工作很重要。到了每个国家，你们要将皇帝[7]的书信和礼物交给国王[8]，也要把他们的话准确地带回来。一句话翻译错了，就可能带来大麻烦。"

10 在这些通事里，有一个叫马欢[9]的人，比阿里大十几岁，也懂阿拉伯文[10]。

1 船员 *chuányuán* sailor
2 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
3 通事 *tōngshì* interpreter
4 郑和 *Zhèng Hé* Zheng He (1371–1433?), admiral of the fleet
5 云南 *Yúnnán* Yunnan province
6 伊斯兰教 *Yīsīlánjiào* Islam
7 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
8 国王 *guówáng* king
9 马欢 *Mǎ Huān* Ma Huan, interpreter and author
10 阿拉伯文 *Ālābówén* Arabic (written language)

There were about twenty-seven thousand people aboard: soldiers, sailors, doc- 8
tors, shipwrights, and interpreters like Ali. Because there were so many people, they needed a great deal, so every ship was loaded with grain, fresh water and goods of all kinds, so that the fleet would lack nothing even after months at sea.

A few days before departure, all the interpreters were called aboard Zheng 9
He's ship. Zheng He was said to be very tall, with a powerful voice. His family name had originally been Ma; he came from Yunnan, and his family were Muslims, just like Ali's. Zheng He looked over the young men and said: "Your work is important. In every country you must deliver the emperor's letters and gifts to the king, and bring his words back accurately. A single sentence translated wrongly could cause serious trouble."

Among the interpreters was a man named Ma Huan, a dozen or so years 10
older than Ali, who also knew Arabic.

10 他走到哪里都带着一个本子，看到什么就记什么。阿里[1]好奇地问他写这些做什么。马欢[2]说："我把看到的都写下来，以便以后的人知道，海的那一边是什么样子。"

星星和罗盘[3]

11 冬天的东北风[4]终于来了。船队离开长乐[5]，一路向南。最初几天，阿里晕船[6]晕[7]得很厉害，什么也吃不下。老陈[8]给他送来一碗热汤，让他到外面去吹吹风。慢慢地，阿里习惯了船的摇动，开始对船上的一切感到好奇。

12 老陈是船上的"火长"[9]，专门负责看方向。白天，他凭罗盘判断方向。罗盘里有一根小小的针，不管船怎么转，它总是指着南方。

1 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
2 马欢 *Mǎ Huān* Ma Huan, interpreter and author
3 罗盘 *luópán* compass
4 东北风 *dōngběifēng* northeast monsoon
5 长乐 *Chánglè* Changle, harbour in Fujian
6 晕船 *yùnchuán* to be seasick
7 晕 *yùn* dizzy, sick
8 老陈 *Lǎo Chén* Old Chen
9 火长 *huǒzhǎng* chief navigator

Wherever he went he carried a notebook and wrote down whatever he saw. Ali 10
asked him curiously what he was writing all this for. Ma Huan said, "I write down everything I see, so that people in the future will know what lies on the other side of the sea."

Stars and Compass

At last the winter northeast wind arrived. The fleet left Changle and headed 11
south. For the first few days Ali was terribly seasick and couldn't keep anything down. Old Chen brought him a bowl of hot soup and told him to go outside and get some air. Little by little Ali got used to the rocking of the ship and began to be curious about everything on board.

Old Chen was the ship's huozhang, the chief navigator, whose special job 12
was to keep the course. By day he went by the compass to judge the direction. Inside the compass was a tiny needle; however the ship turned, it always pointed south.

12 到了晚上，他就拿出一套木头板子，对着天上的星星比来比去。“这叫牵星板[1]，”老陈[2]说，“把板子的下边对着海和天相连的地方，上边对着北极星[3]，看星星有几‘指’高，就能知道船走到了哪里。越往南走，北极星就越低。”

13 阿里[4]问：“要是阴天，看不见星星呢？”老陈说：“那就凭罗盘[5]、海水的颜色，还有经验。走了几十年海路，我不用眼睛看，用鼻子闻就知道离陆地远不远。”他还告诉阿里，船上用烧香的方法计算时间，一天一夜分成十“更”。知道了时间，又知道了方向，就能算出船走了多远，从而在海图[6]上找到船的位置。

14 船队这么大，怎么才能不走散呢？白天，各条船挂起不同的旗子[7]；晚上，就点起灯笼[8]；遇到大雾[9]，就敲鼓。

1 牵星板 *qiānxīngbǎn* star-sighting boards
2 老陈 *Lǎo Chén* Old Chen
3 北极星 *Běijíxīng* Pole Star
4 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
5 罗盘 *luópán* compass
6 海图 *hǎitú* sea chart
7 旗子 *qízi* flag
8 灯笼 *dēnglong* lantern
9 大雾 *dàwù* thick fog

At night he took out a set of wooden boards and held them up against the stars, measuring this way and that. "These are called star-sighting boards," said Old Chen. "Line up the bottom edge of the board with the place where sea meets sky, and the top edge with the Pole Star. See how many 'fingers' high the star stands, and you know where the ship has got to. The further south you go, the lower the Pole Star sits." 12

Ali asked, "What if it's cloudy and you can't see the stars?" Old Chen said, "Then you go by the compass, the colour of the water, and experience. After decades on the sea roads, I don't even need my eyes; I can smell whether land is near or far." He also told Ali that on board they kept time by burning incense, dividing a day and a night into ten "watches". Knowing the time and the direction, you can work out how far the ship has sailed, and thereby find its position on the chart. 13

With a fleet this large, how could the ships keep from getting scattered? By day each ship flew its own flags; at night they lit lanterns; in thick fog they beat drums. 14

14 这样，船和船之间可以随时互相联系，从而一直保持在一起。

15 有一天夜里，海上忽然起了风暴[1]。海浪[2]比船还高，雨像石头一样打在船上。阿里[3]紧紧地抓着船边，听见四周的鼓声一直响着。天亮的时候，风停了。阿里数了数远处的船帆[4]，一条船也没少。他松了一口气，第一次觉得，这支船队不只是大，更像一个人，每个部分都在一起呼吸。

远方[5]的港口[6]

16 船队先后到了占城[7]、爪哇[8]、满剌加[9]和苏门答剌[10]，又经过锡兰[11]，在海上走了好几个月，终于到了古里[12]。

1 风暴 *fēngbào* storm
2 海浪 *hǎilàng* waves
3 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
4 船帆 *chuánfān* sail
5 远方 *yuǎnfāng* distant lands
6 港口 *gǎngkǒu* port
7 占城 *Zhànchéng* Champa (central Vietnam)
8 爪哇 *Zhǎowā* Java
9 满剌加 *Mǎnlàjiā* Malacca
10 苏门答剌 *Sūméndálà* Samudera (Sumatra)
11 锡兰 *Xīlán* Ceylon (Sri Lanka)
12 古里 *Gǔlǐ* Calicut (Kozhikode, India)

In this way the ships could stay in touch with one another at all times, and so keep together. 14

One night a storm suddenly blew up. The waves rose higher than the ships, and the rain struck them like stones. Ali held on tight to the side of the ship and heard the drums all around beating without pause. At daybreak the wind dropped. Ali counted the sails in the distance: not a single ship was missing. He breathed a sigh of relief, and for the first time felt that the fleet was not just big; it was more like a single person, every part of it breathing together. 15

Distant Ports

The fleet called in turn at Champa, Java, Malacca and Samudera, passed Ceylon, and after many months at sea at last reached Calicut. 16

16 每到一个地方，船队都停下来，送礼物，交换货，从而跟这些国家建立了联系。古里[1]在印度[2]的西南海边，是有名的贸易港口[3]。阿里[4]一下船就闻到了一种熟悉的味道——是胡椒[5]！他这才知道，父亲店里卖的胡椒，很多就是从这样的地方运来的。

17 在古里做生意的方法很特别。中国的货运上岸以后，国王[6]派来官和当地的商人，大家坐在一起，一件一件地商量价格。马欢[7]小声对阿里说："你看，他们计算不用算盘[8]，只用两只手和两只脚上的二十个指头[9]，算得又快又准，一点儿也不错。"价格商量好以后，双方把手拍在一起，就算定下来了，以后谁也不能再改。船队就这样将丝绸[10]和瓷器[11]换成了胡椒、宝石和珍珠。

1 古里 *Gǔlǐ* Calicut (Kozhikode, India)
2 印度 *Yìndù* India
3 港口 *gǎngkǒu* port
4 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
5 胡椒 *hújiāo* black pepper
6 国王 *guówáng* king
7 马欢 *Mǎ Huān* Ma Huan, interpreter and author
8 算盘 *suànpán* abacus
9 指头 *zhǐtou* fingers and toes
10 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
11 瓷器 *cíqì* porcelain

At every place the fleet stopped, gave gifts and exchanged goods, and in this way built ties with these countries. Calicut lies on the southwest coast of India and was a famous trading port. As soon as he stepped off the ship, Ali caught a familiar smell: pepper! Only then did he realise that much of the pepper in his father's shop came from places like this. 16

In Calicut, business was done in a special way. Once the Chinese goods were brought ashore, the king sent officials and local merchants, and everyone sat down together to settle prices item by item. Ma Huan whispered to Ali, "Look, they don't use an abacus to reckon. They use nothing but the twenty fingers and toes on their hands and feet, and they're fast and exact, never off by the smallest bit." When a price was agreed, both sides struck their hands together and the deal was fixed; after that, no one could change it. In this way the fleet turned its silk and porcelain into pepper, gems and pearls. 17

18 有一次，一个阿拉伯[1]商人说了一句话，一个年轻的通事[2]翻译得太快，中国的官一听，以为对方看不起中国的瓷器[3]，脸色马上就变了。阿里[4]赶紧又问了商人一遍，才弄明白：他的意思不是瓷器不好，而是这么好的东西，他怕自己的钱不够。阿里把这个意思重新翻译了一遍，双方都笑了。

19 那天晚上，阿里在自己的本子上写道：“以前我以为，通事只是把一种话变成另[5]一种话。现在我才明白，我们要让双方真正明白对方的心，从而避免误会。以前我觉得，船队出海是为了让别的国家看看中国有多强大。现在我觉得，更重要的，也许是人和人之间的交流。”

20 离开古里[6]以后，船队继续向西，第一次来到了忽鲁谟斯[7]。

1 阿拉伯 *Ālābó* Arab, Arabic
2 通事 *tōngshì* interpreter
3 瓷器 *cíqì* porcelain
4 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
5 另 *lìng* another
6 古里 *Gǔlǐ* Calicut (Kozhikode, India)
7 忽鲁谟斯 *Hūlǔmósī* Hormuz

Once an Arab merchant said something, a young interpreter translated it too hastily, and when the Chinese official heard it, he thought the man looked down on Chinese porcelain. His face changed at once. Ali quickly asked the merchant again and only then understood: he didn't mean the porcelain was bad, but that for such fine things, he feared his money would not be enough. Ali translated his meaning again, and both sides laughed. 18

That night Ali wrote in his notebook: "I used to think an interpreter simply turned one language into another. Now I understand that we must help both sides truly understand each other's hearts, and so avoid misunderstandings. I used to think the fleet sailed to show other countries how mighty China was. Now I think that what matters more may be the exchange between people." 19

After leaving Calicut, the fleet continued west and for the first time reached Hormuz. 20

20 这里在波斯湾[1]的入口，天气又干又热，很少下雨，可是市场上到处是从各地来的商人和货。阿里[2]在市场上听见有人说波斯[3]话，就像听见了爷爷的声音。他跟一位老商人谈了很久。老商人说："很多年以前，我爷爷的船也去过泉州[4]。"两个人都觉得，大海虽然很宽，世界其实并不大。

一只长颈鹿[5]

21 1415年夏天，船队回到了中国。跟着船队一起来的，还有很多国家的使者[6]。他们带来了各种礼物，有宝石，有香料[7]，还有一些中国人从来没见过的动物。其中最让人吃惊的，是一只长颈鹿。据说它来自非洲[8]东岸的麻林国[9]。它的脖子[10]和腿都特别长，站起来比两个人加起来还高。

1 波斯湾 *Bōsīwān* the Persian Gulf
2 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
3 波斯 *Bōsī* Persia
4 泉州 *Quánzhōu* Quanzhou, port city in Fujian
5 长颈鹿 *chángjǐnglù* giraffe
6 使者 *shǐzhě* envoy
7 香料 *xiāngliào* spices
8 非洲 *Fēizhōu* Africa
9 麻林国 *Málínguó* Malindi (in today's Kenya)
10 脖子 *bózi* neck

It lay at the mouth of the Persian Gulf; the weather was hot and dry and it 20
seldom rained, but the markets were crowded with merchants and goods from everywhere. In the market Ali heard someone speaking Persian, and it was like hearing his grandfather's voice. He talked with an old merchant for a long time. The old man said, "Many years ago my grandfather's ship went to Quanzhou too." Both of them felt that, wide as the sea was, the world was not really so big.

A Giraffe

In the summer of 1415 the fleet returned to China. With it came envoys 21
from many countries. They brought all kinds of gifts: gems, spices, and some animals the Chinese had never seen before. The most astonishing of all was a giraffe. It is said to have come from Malindi, on the east coast of Africa. Its neck and legs were extraordinarily long, and standing up it was taller than two men put together.

22 长颈鹿[1]被送到南京[2]的那天，街上挤满了来看的人。朝廷[3]里的大臣[4]们看了，都说这是传说中的“麒麟[5]”。在中国的传说里，只有国家和平、皇帝[6]是好皇帝的时候，麒麟才会出现。于是，长颈鹿就被叫做麒麟，还有画家专门为它画了画。大臣们纷纷向皇帝祝贺。

23 阿里[7]被派去给麻林国[8]的使者[9]做翻译，以便使者和大臣们能互相交流。使者会说阿拉伯[10]话，他悄悄地问阿里：“你们为什么叫它‘麒麟’？在我们那里，它只是一种普通的动物，草原上到处都能看到。”阿里想了想，回答说：“在你们那里，它是普通的动物；可是在这里，它代表着好运和和平。一样的东西，在不同的地方，会有不同的意义。”使者笑了：“那么，我们送来的不只是一只动物，还是一个好消息。”

1 长颈鹿 *chángjǐnglù* giraffe
2 南京 *Nánjīng* Nanjing, then the capital
3 朝廷 *cháotíng* imperial court
4 大臣 *dàchén* minister
5 麒麟 *qílín* qilin, auspicious mythical beast
6 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
7 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
8 麻林国 *Málínguó* Malindi (in today's Kenya)
9 使者 *shǐzhě* envoy
10 阿拉伯 *Ālābó* Arab, Arabic

On the day the giraffe was brought to Nanjing, the streets were packed with people who had come to look. When the ministers at court saw it, they all said it was the qilin of legend. In Chinese legend, the qilin appears only when the country is at peace and the emperor is a good one. So the giraffe came to be called a qilin, and a painter even made a picture of it. One minister after another offered the emperor congratulations. 22

Ali was sent to interpret for the envoy from Malindi, so that the envoy and the ministers could talk with each other. The envoy spoke Arabic, and he quietly asked Ali, "Why do you call it a 'qilin'? Where we come from, it's just an ordinary animal; you can see them all over the grasslands." Ali thought for a moment and replied, "Where you live it's an ordinary animal, but here it stands for good fortune and peace. The same thing can mean different things in different places." The envoy smiled. "Then what we've brought is not just an animal, but good news as well." 23

24 两年以后，船队第五次出海，把这些使者[1]送回了自己的国家，阿里[2]也在船上。他站在船头，看着越来越远的陆地，心里想：只要船还在走，两边的人就会越来越了解对方。

船队不再[3]出发

25 后来，阿里又跟着船队出了几次海。1424年，永乐[4]皇帝[5]去世，新皇帝很快就命令停止下西洋[6]。又过了几年，船队再一次出发，这就是第七次，也是最后一次下西洋。大约在1433年，郑和[7]去世了。有人说他死在回国的路上，也有别的说法，到今天还没有人能确定。

26 朝廷[8]里，很多大臣[9]反对再派船队出海。

1 使者 *shǐzhě* envoy
2 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
3 不再 *bùzài* no longer
4 永乐 *Yǒnglè* Yongle (reign title, 1403–1424)
5 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
6 下西洋 *xià Xīyáng* voyages to the Western Seas
7 郑和 *Zhèng Hé* Zheng He (1371–1433?), admiral of the fleet
8 朝廷 *cháotíng* imperial court
9 大臣 *dàchén* minister

Two years later the fleet put to sea for the fifth time to carry these envoys back to their own countries, and Ali was on board. Standing at the bow, watching the land fall away behind them, he thought: as long as the ships keep sailing, the people on both sides will come to understand each other better and better. 24

The Fleet Sails No More

After that, Ali went to sea with the fleet several more times. In 1424 the Yongle Emperor died, and the new emperor soon ordered the voyages to the Western Seas to stop. A few years later the fleet set out once more: the seventh and last voyage to the Western Seas. Around 1433, Zheng He died. Some say he died on the voyage home, but there are other accounts too, and no one can be sure even today. 25

At court, many ministers opposed sending the fleet out again. 26

26 他们说，造船、买货、送礼物，花了太多的钱，可是带回来的大多是宝石、香料[1]和奇怪的动物，对老百姓没有什么用。再加上北方的边境不安全，朝廷[2]需要把钱用在那里。由于这些原因，因此朝廷再也没有派船队下西洋[3]。

27 很多年过去了，阿里[4]的头发已经白了。他回到泉州[5]，接过了父亲的店，还是卖胡椒[6]。有一天，一个从南京[7]来的商人告诉他，船厂里那些巨大的宝船[8]，已经很多年没有人修了，有的被雨水泡[9]坏了，有的被拆了当木头用。“听说朝廷将不再[10]派船下西洋，”商人说，“以后，海上恐怕再也看不到那样的船队了。”

28 阿里的小孙子听了，跑过来问：“爷爷，船不去了，那些远方[11]的国家还会记得我们吗？”

1 香料 *xiāngliào* spices
2 朝廷 *cháotíng* imperial court
3 下西洋 *xià Xīyáng* voyages to the Western Seas
4 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
5 泉州 *Quánzhōu* Quanzhou, port city in Fujian
6 胡椒 *hújiāo* black pepper
7 南京 *Nánjīng* Nanjing, then the capital
8 宝船 *bǎochuán* treasure ship
9 泡 *pào* to soak
10 不再 *bùzài* no longer
11 远方 *yuǎnfāng* distant lands

They said that building ships, buying goods and giving gifts had cost far too much, while what came back was mostly gems, spices and strange animals, of no use to ordinary people. On top of that, the northern frontier was unsafe, and the court needed its money there. For these reasons, the court never again sent a fleet to the Western Seas. 26

Many years went by, and Ali's hair turned white. He had gone back to Quanzhou and taken over his father's shop, and he still sold pepper. One day a merchant from Nanjing told him that the huge treasure ships in the shipyard had gone unrepaired for years; some had rotted in the rain, and some had been broken up for timber. "I hear the court will send no more ships to the Western Seas," the merchant said. "I'm afraid we'll never see a fleet like that on the sea again." 27

Ali's little grandson heard this, ran over and asked, "Grandpa, if the ships don't go any more, will those faraway countries still remember us?" 28

28 阿里[1]没有马上回答。他从柜子里拿出一个旧本子，那是他年轻时在船上写的。纸已经发黄了，上面记着古里[2]的胡椒[3]、忽鲁谟斯[4]的市场、长颈鹿[5]长长的脖子[6]，还有老陈[7]教他认的星星。他又想起了马欢[8]。听说马欢的书《瀛涯胜览[9]》已经写完了，有人正在抄写，以便让更多的人读到。

29 “船不去了，”阿里慢慢地说，“可是我们见过的东西，学过的话，交过的朋友，不会一下子就消失。”那天晚上，他一个人走到海边，抬头看着天上的北极星[10]。年轻的时候，他凭这颗星知道自己在哪里；现在，他却不知道，一个不再[11]出海的国家，将会走向哪里。

1 阿里 *Ālǐ* Ali
2 古里 *Gǔlǐ* Calicut (Kozhikode, India)
3 胡椒 *hújiāo* black pepper
4 忽鲁谟斯 *Hūlǔmósī* Hormuz
5 长颈鹿 *chángjǐnglù* giraffe
6 脖子 *bózi* neck
7 老陈 *Lǎo Chén* Old Chen
8 马欢 *Mǎ Huān* Ma Huan, interpreter and author
9 瀛涯胜览 *Yíngyá Shènglǎn* The Overall Survey of the Ocean's Shores (Ma Huan's book)
10 北极星 *Běijíxīng* Pole Star
11 不再 *bùzài* no longer

Ali didn't answer at once. He took an old notebook out of the cupboard, the one he had kept on board when he was young. The paper had yellowed. In it were notes on the pepper of Calicut, the markets of Hormuz, the giraffe's long neck, and the stars Old Chen had taught him to recognise. He thought of Ma Huan too. He had heard that Ma Huan's book, The Overall Survey of the Ocean's Shores, was finished, and that people were copying it out so that more readers could see it. 28

"The ships may not go any more," Ali said slowly, "but the things we saw, the languages we learned and the friends we made won't vanish all at once." That night he walked alone to the shore and looked up at the Pole Star. When he was young, this star had told him where he was. Now he did not know where a country that no longer went to sea would be heading. 29